Warne ineffective – he conceded more than six runs an over in his spell – the Australians were forced to turn to Tom Moody. We attacked him throughout his spell and also put pressure on Australia's irregular bowlers, Mark and Steve Waugh.

By the time I finally got out for 134, the result was a mere formality. We needed just 24 from six overs. As I was walking back to the pavilion I could see Mark Mascarenhas waiting for me next to the sightscreen. I was soaked in sweat and, seeing Mark was about to give me a hug, I remember warning him that he would spoil his smart clothes. Mark wasn't bothered and he lifted me up into the air with a smile.

The post-match presentation turned out to be really special. Steve Waugh said that they had lost to *me*, which was quite something coming from the Australian captain on a day which also happened to be my twenty-fifth birthday. There could have been no better birthday present.

During the presentation an announcement was made by Coca-Cola that they had decided to give me a Mercedes SL600. I have always been interested in cars and remembered my first introduction to a variety of fancy cars such as BMWs on my first trip to England with the Star Cricket Club in 1988.

Good to be back

On our return to Mumbai we were greeted by a sea of humanity and it was touching to see fans showering such warmth on the players. In the ultimate analysis, we play for our fans and to be able to make them happy has always been extremely important.

Sometimes things can get a little out of hand, however. After coming back from Sharjah I was invited to a double-wicket tournament at the Shivaji Park Gymkhana in Mumbai. Pravin Amre called me and said the organizers were keen for me to go along to encourage the players. Shivaji Park has always been special to me and I decided to take Anjali with me. When we arrived we found that a huge crowd had assembled to see me. My visit had caused a law-and-order situation and in the end it was difficult to get away from the chaos. We somehow managed to leave Shivaji Park Gymkhana for home and I felt humbled at the affection I had received. Fans asking for autographs always made me feel special and I make it a point to oblige them whenever I can. The people who wait for hours are the ones who make the game what it is in India and we